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Applying for a study visa in Belgium as a non-EU student involves a two-stage process: obtaining a Type D (Long-stay) Visa before departure and securing an A-Card (Residence Permit) after arrival.

Below is the updated information for the 2025–2026 and 2026–2027 academic years, based on official Belgian Immigration Office (IBZ) regulations.

1. Study Courses

To qualify for a study visa, you must be enrolled in one of the following:

- Higher Education: A full-time Bachelor's, Master's, or PhD program at a recognized university or higher education institution.
- Preparatory Year: A year of study to prepare for higher education (e.g., language courses or specific academic preparation).
- Student Exchange/Mobility: Programs like Erasmus+ or other official mobility schemes.
- Secondary Education: In specific cases, student exchange programs at the secondary school level.

2. Embassy Appointment

Appointments are typically booked through a third-party service provider or the "Visa on Web" portal:

- Portal: Register and fill out your application on the Visa On Web (VOW) site first.
- Service Providers: Depending on your country, you must book the physical appointment through VFS Global or TLScontact.
- Timing: Book at least 2–3 months before your course starts. Applications can be submitted up to 6 months in advance.
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be / diplomatie.belgium.be): For a long-stay visa, it is recommended to book at least 2 months (not 2–3 months) before departure. Applications can be submitted up to 6 months in advance.

3. Applying for a Study Visa: Steps & Timeline

1. Obtain Admission: Receive an official letter of acceptance from a recognized Belgian institution.
2. Pay the Administrative Fee: Most students must pay a fee to the Belgian Immigration Office before applying (€251 for Higher Education as of 2026).
3. Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Contribution fee): As of 1 January 2026, €251 applies to students at public higher education institutions. Students at private higher education institutions pay €242. Scholarship holders from qualifying bodies are exempt.
4. Gather Documents: Prepare the checklist (see Section 4).
5. Submit Application: Visit the embassy/center for biometrics (fingerprints and photo) and document submission.
6. Processing Time: Usually takes 2 to 8 weeks, but can take up to 3 months for private institutions or during peak seasons (July–September).

4. Documents Needed

- Passport: Valid for at least 12 months.
- Visa Application Form: Printed and signed from the VOW portal.
- Admission Letter: Proof of registration or enrollment.
- Proof of Solvency: Evidence you can support yourself (see Section 5).
- Medical Certificate: From an embassy-approved doctor, stating you are not carrying specific infectious diseases.
- Criminal Record Certificate: A “Certificate of Good Conduct” (if you are 18+), legalized or with an Apostille.
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Initial authorisation to stay): Per the Belgian Immigration Office, the criminal record extract must be issued by the competent authority of the country of origin or last residence, must not be older than 6 months at time of application, and must be legalized or apostilled. The 18+ age threshold is correct.
- Proof of Health Insurance: Valid for Belgium.
- Administrative Fee Receipt: Proof of payment of the €251 contribution fee.

5. Money Requirements (Proof of Solvency)

Belgium significantly increased the financial threshold for the 2026–2027 academic year.

- Amount (2025–2026): €835 per month.
- Amount (2026–2027): €1,062 net per month.
- Total for one year: Approximately €12,744.
- Methods of Proof:

- Blocked Account: Transferring the total annual amount to a Belgian bank or the university, which pays it back to you monthly. (Highly recommended).
- Scholarship: An official certificate of a grant or scholarship.
- Guarantor (Annex 32): A sponsor (in Belgium or abroad) who meets high income requirements (€3,235.88 net/month as of 2026) and signs a formal obligation.

6. Residence Permit (After Arrival)

- Within 8 working days of arriving in Belgium, you must visit the local Commune (Town Hall) of your place of residence.
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Introduced abroad (Visa D)): The Belgian Immigration Office states the deadline is within 8 days of arrival, not specifically 8 working days. [Art. 102 of the Royal Decree of 8 October 1981]
- Process: Register your address. The police will visit to verify you live there.
- Result: You will receive an A-Card (electronic residence permit), which serves as your ID and allows travel within the Schengen Area.

7. Working While Studying

- Allowed Hours: You can work up to 20 hours per week during the school term.
- Holidays: You can work unlimited hours during official school holidays (Summer, Christmas, etc.).
- Requirement: Your residence permit (A-Card) will typically mention “Labor Market: Limited,” meaning you do not need a separate work permit for these hours.

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

The A-Card is usually valid for one year. You must apply for renewal at your local commune at least 15 days before it expires.

- Academic Progress: You must prove “sufficient study progress” (e.g., earning at least 45 credits over two years for a Bachelor’s).
- Documents: Updated enrollment, proof of solvency, and health insurance.

9. Changing to a Work Permit (Orientation Year)

After graduating with a Bachelor’s, Master’s, or PhD in Belgium, you can apply for an Orientation Year (Search Year):

- Duration: 12 months.

- Purpose: To look for a job or start a business.
- Benefit: During this year, you have unrestricted access to the Belgian labor market. Once you find a job meeting the minimum salary threshold, your employer will apply for a Single Permit (Work + Residence).

10. Official Information

- Belgian Immigration Office (IBZ): dofi.ibz.be (The primary legal source).
- FPS Foreign Affairs: diplomatie.belgium.be (For embassy locations and visa types).
- Study in Flanders / Study in Wallonia: Official regional portals for education.

11. Application Forms

- Visa Application (Long Stay): Available on the Visa On Web portal.
- Financial Guarantee (Annex 32): Can be downloaded from the IBZ website.

12. Tips for Students (Avoiding Common Mistakes)

- Incomplete “Originals”: Embassies often reject printed emails as “originals.” Always request a physical, stamped admission letter if possible.
- Insufficient Guarantor Income: Ensure your sponsor’s income is well above the required threshold after their own taxes and debts.
- Late Criminal Record Checks: These can take weeks to obtain and legalize (Apostille). Start this process early.
- Translation Errors: Documents not in English, French, Dutch, or German must be translated by a sworn translator.

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1. Study Courses

You are authorised to come to Belgium to study if you are legally enrolled in an institution of higher education or university recognised by the Belgian authorities to follow a full course of study or to undertake a preparatory year.

Eligible programmes include:

- Bachelor's degrees
- Master's degrees
- Doctoral programmes
- Post-graduate programmes
- Associate programmes
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Initial authorisation to stay): The Belgian Immigration Office does not list “Post-graduate programmes” and “Associate programmes” as separate student visa eligibility categories. Eligibility is for full-time study at a recognised higher education institution (including Bachelor's, Master's, and Doctoral programmes) or a recognised preparatory/foundation year. Always verify programme eligibility with your institution and the IBZ.
- Recognised preparatory/foundation years

Special rule for Chinese students:

Students from the People's Republic of China must obtain an academic evaluation certificate issued by the Academic Assessment Centre (APS) before being authorised to enrol in a higher education institution in Belgium.

2. Embassy Appointment

For a long-stay study visa, it is recommended that you make an appointment at the embassy at least two months before your departure. For a short-stay visa, make an appointment at least 3 weeks before your departure.

At some embassies/consulates, you can make an appointment online by sending an email to the embassy and uploading the required documents. You will receive an answer within the next 2 working days with a confirmation of your appointment.

In some regions, Belgium collaborates with external service providers, such as VFS Global. If so, your application will go through their booking system.

To find your competent embassy, visit: diplomatie.belgium.be

3. Applying for a Study Visa

Visa types:

- Type C Short-Stay Visa — for academic programmes of less than 90 days
- Type D Long-Stay Visa — for academic programmes of more than 90 days

Steps to apply:

1. Get accepted at a recognised Belgian university or institution
2. Complete the visa application form through Belgium's Visa On Web system, managed by the Belgian Immigration Office — create an account, fill in your details, and generate the application form
3. Collect all required documents (see Section 4)
4. Book an embassy or consulate appointment and submit documents in person
5. During the appointment, biometric data including fingerprints and a photo will be collected

Processing time:

- Once you have submitted your application, you will usually receive a decision within 15 days
- During busy periods, the processing time can reach up to 90 days
- Apply at least 3 months before your intended start date to be safe

4. Documents Needed

Required documents for the Type D student visa:

- Completed and signed visa application form
- Passport valid for at least 12 months when you arrive in Belgium
- Proof of sufficient funds (see Section 5)
- Medical certificate
- **Proof of no criminal convictions (for applicants over 21 only)**
- **Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Initial authorisation to stay / Certificate of absence of convictions):** Per the Belgian Immigration Office, the criminal record extract is required for applicants aged 18 and over, not 21 and over. The document must be issued by the competent authority of the country of origin or last

residence, must not be older than 6 months at time of application, and must be legalised or apostilled. [Article 60 of the Act of 15 December 1980]

- Proof of registration at a university in Belgium
- Original and certified copy of your higher secondary education diploma or equivalent
- Supporting letter explaining your choice of studies
- Proof of language proficiency

Document language rules:

- All documents supplied in a language other than French, German, English, or Dutch must be translated by a sworn translator and then legalised as a separate document

5. Money Requirements

- Proof of sufficient funds must cover healthcare, living costs, study, and repatriation costs
- The minimum amount is set at 803 euros per month for the 2024/2025 academic year, although most universities will ask for around 850 euros per month
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Sufficient means of subsistence): The figure of €803/month applied to 2024/2025 and is now outdated. The current minimum is €835 net/month for the 2025–2026 academic year, and €1,062 net/month for 2026–2027, as set by Royal Decree and indexed annually. Always check the current amount on dofi.ibz.be before applying.

6. Residence Permit

- After arrival in Belgium, you must register at the municipality of your place of residence within 8 working days
- Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Introduced abroad (Visa D)): The Belgian Immigration Office states the deadline is within 8 days of arrival, not 8 working days. [Article 102 of the Royal Decree of 8 October 1981]
- The municipality then issues a residence permit for a limited period of time, known as the A-card
- The residence permit for students is valid for a period of up to one academic year plus one month and is renewable

7. Working While Studying

- During the academic year, you can work a maximum of 20 hours per week
- During official holiday periods such as winter, spring, or summer holidays, you can work more than 20 hours per week
- You can work for any employer in Belgium as long as you have a valid residence permit
- As of January 2020, international students no longer need a separate type C work permit

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

- Apply for renewal at the municipality of your place of residence at the latest 15 days before your residence permit expires
- Your application can be rejected if there is insufficient study progress

Study progress requirements:

- Bachelor's or graduate students must obtain a total of 45 credits in the first two years and 45 credits for each subsequent year
- Master's students must obtain a total of 60 credits in the first two years and 60 credits for each subsequent year

9. Changing to a Work Permit

The Search Year (Orientation Year):

- After completing studies in Belgium, a third-country national may ask to extend their stay for a maximum of 12 months in order to look for work or set up a company
- During the search year, you have unlimited access to the Belgian labour market and can work full-time
- The application must be submitted to the local authority of your place of residence at least 15 days before your A-card expires

Documents required for the search year:

- Valid passport
- Proof of degree from a recognised Belgian higher education institution
- Proof of health insurance
- **Proof of sufficient resources (803 euros per month net for 2024/2025)**
- **Correction (dofi.ibz.be – Sufficient means of subsistence):** The figure of €803/month is outdated. The applicable minimum is €835 net/month for 2025–

2026 and €1,062 net/month for 2026–2027. Verify the current indexed amount on dofi.ibz.be before applying.

After the search year:

- If you find employment during your search year, you can switch to a single permit, which is a combined residence and work permit
- Belgian employers are generally familiar with this process, but it is best to start applications early as paperwork can take several months

10. Official Information

- Immigration Office (IBZ) — main authority: dofi.ibz.be
- FPS Foreign Affairs — visas: diplomatie.belgium.be
- EU Immigration Portal — Belgium: home-affairs.ec.europa.eu
- Study in Flanders: studyinlanders.be
- Visa On Web online application portal: visaonweb.be

11. Application Forms

- Visa application form: available through the Visa On Web portal at visaonweb.be
- In rare cases, some embassies may still accept paper forms — always check the website of the Belgian embassy or consulate where you will apply
- Annexes for the residence permit: available at dofi.ibz.be under Documentation, then Legislation (available in French and Dutch only)

12. Tips for Students — Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Applying too late — apply at least 3 months before your start date
- Submitting incomplete documents — check the full list on your embassy's website before applying
- Submitting untranslated documents — all non-English, French, German, or Dutch documents must be translated by a sworn translator
- **Not registering at the municipality on arrival — you must do this within 8 working days**
- **Correction (dofi.ibz.be): The deadline to register is within 8 days of arrival, not 8 working days.**
- Forgetting to renew the residence permit — apply at least 15 days before the A-card expires
- Not meeting credit requirements — track your academic progress each year to avoid rejection at renewal

- Working more than 20 hours per week during term time — stay within the legal limit to protect your visa status
- Missing the Search Year deadline — apply before your student A-card expires, not after

Always verify the latest requirements directly with the Belgian Immigration Office at dofi.ibz.be and the Belgian embassy in your home country, as rules are updated each academic year.